

FILMS AND FILM-MAKING



IN 1895, THE Lumière brothers held the first public film screening, in a room below a Parisian café. The black and white images flickered on a silent screen, yet the audience was enthralled. The magic of the movies has continued ever since. Technology developed rapidly: sound arrived in 1927, colour in the 1930s, and today's complex films often involve stunning special effects. Film production is now an international industry, generating great wealth and employing thousands worldwide.

Casting

It is vital to the success of a movie to cast (place) actors who suit their parts artistically. Audiences have their favourites, so the choice of a popular star can turn a promising film into a huge box-office success.

Pre-production

Film-making begins long before the cameras start to turn. After a studio (a film-making company) agrees to make a movie, a script is prepared, the budget drawn up, actors and skilled crew hired, and the entire production planned to the last detail.



Pictures represent each shot.



The producer

A producer decides which film to make, finds the money to finance it (often millions of pounds), and brings together the stars, script, and director.

Storyboard

With one small picture for each shot, a storyboard is important in planning a film and gives an idea of what it will look like. Notes outline the action and dialogue.

Focus puller has a seat at top of crane to adjust the focus on the camera lens.

The set designer uses sketches and models to design the set.

The set decorator finds props and decorates set.

Powerful light

Boom holds microphone near actor but out of shot.

Boom operator sits here to position the microphone.

Director's folding chair next to camera

When the actors move, grips push the stand to move the microphone.

The camera operator sits here to work the camera during shooting.

The camera and camera equipment on set are moved by the grip.

Crane raises the camera above the actors' heads.

Production

When filming begins, a movie set is crowded with equipment, and each piece is the responsibility of a specific member of the crew. Between takes (sequences of filming), everyone works frantically to ensure that everything is adjusted exactly as the director wants. Off the set, props, wardrobe, and make-up have their own staff on hand.

Motion pictures

The continuous action on a movie screen is, in fact, an illusion. What we are watching are thousands of still photographs, taken rapidly one after the other. A film camera shoots 24 photographs (frames) every second, and when the images are projected at the same rate, our eyes merge the pictures together. Over 27 m (90 ft) of film is shot for just one minute of cinema.



The director

Responsible for the artistic side of the film-making process, the director is the most important person on set. Directors control the action and judge how well each take brings the script to life. They consult with experts in each department, such as the director of photography, who is responsible for the way the film looks.

Post-production

Separate scenes in a film are shot in whatever order suits the crew. Then the director chooses the best sections, and the film editor links them in the right sequence to tell the story. While working closely with the director and other technicians, the editor carefully aligns the sound track and pictures, and adds the special effects.

Screen to view the film

Loudspeaker plays back sound track

Editing table



Editing

The editor cuts up the disjointed sequences of film, cutting between frames, and splices them together. Cuts are viewed at an editing table.

Sound track

Music, the actors' speech, and any background sound effects are each recorded separately and then combined to make the sound track.